

dren. The lack of paediatric facilities in jail puts them at a high risk of exposure to chronic ailments. Their mental development is also stunted because there is little effort to educate them in day-care centres.

These conditions remain the same despite Supreme Court guidelines issued in April 2006, which clearly state that a child should not be treated as a convict while in jail with the mother. The guidelines state that nurseries should be set up outside the prison premises as a child's development is harmed when staying amidst violent convicts. They go on to state that

after the child is sent out of prison, he or she must be admitted to an institution in the same city as the prison. But these guidelines are widely ignored because there is no law to ensure they are implemented. "Nothing much has changed even now after the guidelines were issued because jails are understaffed and short of funds," says Professor B.N. Chatteraj from the National Institute of Criminology and Forensic Sciences.

The only mental stimulation and social development these children receive is in the day-care centres organised by NGOs in the prison prem-

ises. The volunteers teach the alphabet, nursery rhymes, songs and organise games for them. However, this facility too is not made available all the time. "If there are one or two children living with their mothers, the jail authorities do not think it is feasible to organise day-care for them," says Santosh Nanaware, programme officer of Varhad, an NGO in Amravati, Maharashtra, that works for their welfare. Despite a letter Varhad has written to the inspector general of prisons inquiring about the set up of crèches within the premises a response is still awaited.

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SEVEN-MONTH-OLD JOSHUA (LEFT) WITH HIS 32-YEAR-OLD MOTHER NAOMI, IN JAIL FOR A DRUG-RELATED OFFENCE; 9-MONTH-OLD ROSANNE (ABOVE) WITH HER 27-YEAR-OLD MOTHER EVA JENNIFER ANTONY, A FORMER CALL CENTRE EMPLOYEE WHO IS AN UNDERTRIAL IN A MURDER CASE

Some jails don't even have a separate women's ward and women are clubbed with men. "It is surprising to note that the surveyed jails are overcrowded and no separate women ward is found in most," the Children of Women Prisoners in Jails (A Study in Uttar Pradesh) said. Prisons in Azamgarh, Jaunpur, Varanasi, Meerut and Muzaffarnagar are among the many jails that do not have separate wards for men and women. The crux of the problem lies in the fact that prison authorities see their primary role as one of providing security when they should also be looking at reformation. These children should be tended to by trained officers who are sensitive in dealing